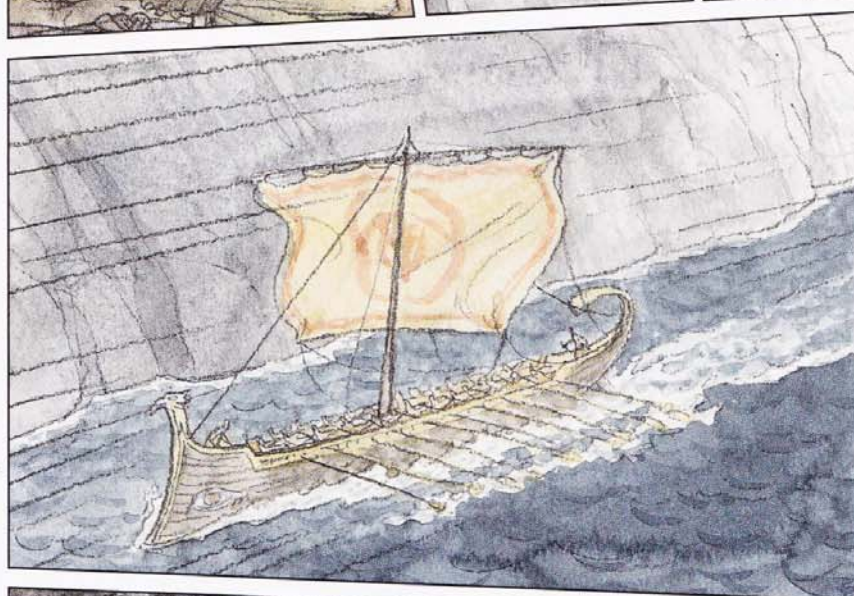


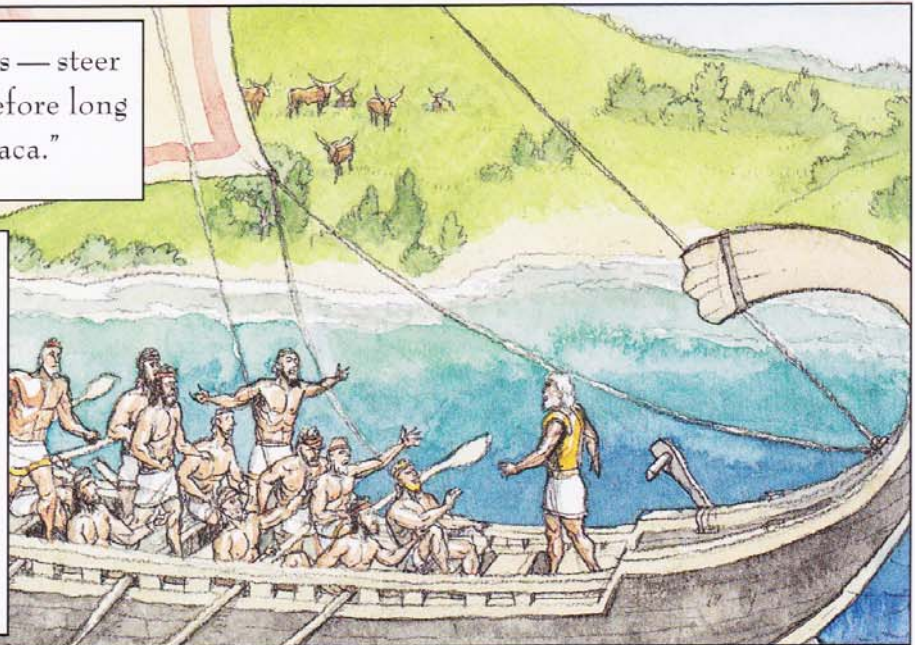




"After that, you will see the island of Thrinacia, where the sun god Helios keeps his divine cattle, tended by two immortal nymphs."

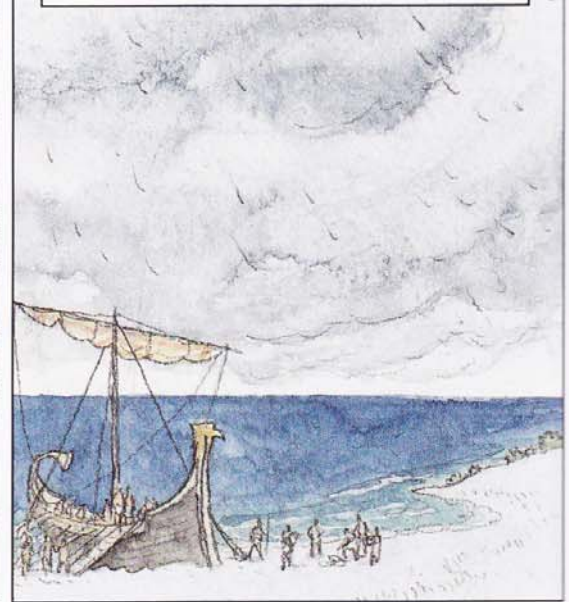
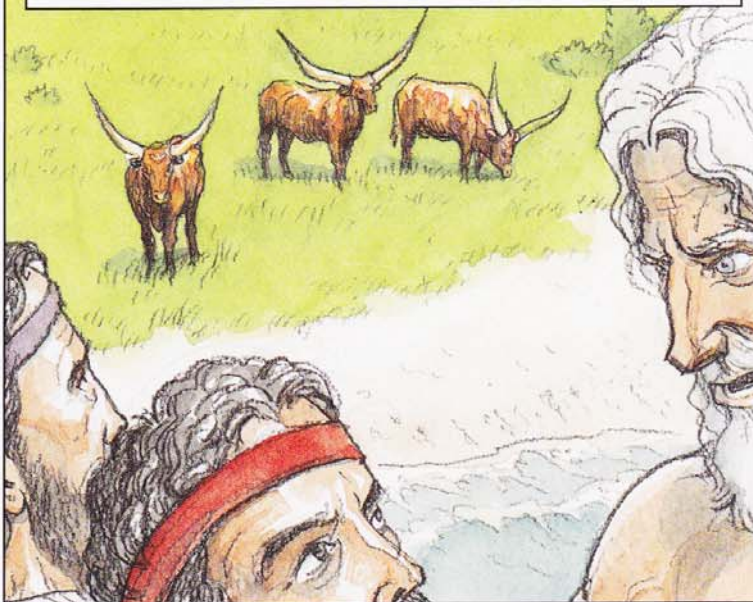
"Remember Tiresias's words — steer clear of that island, and before long you'll make landfall in Ithaca."

I remembered it well, and told the crew repeatedly. But when we came in sight of that sunny island, with its green meadows and bubbling streams, my exhausted men clamored to land.



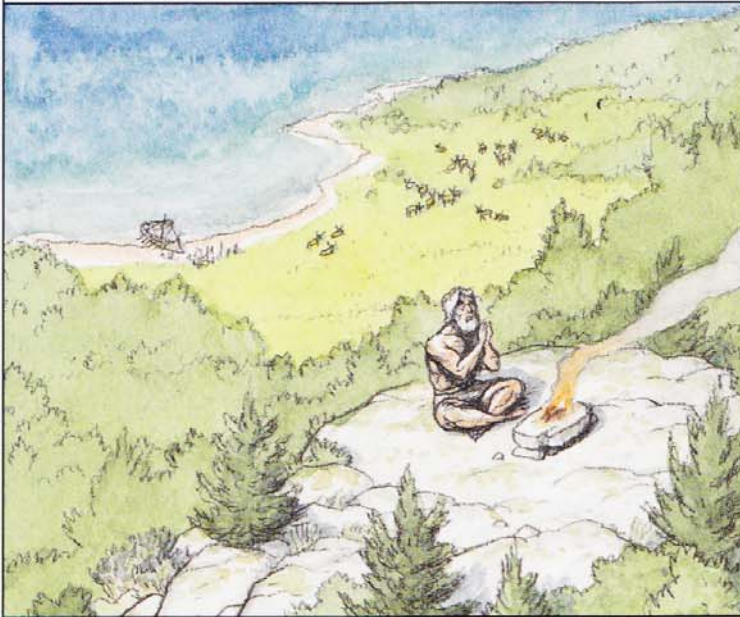
They were mutinous, and I saw that fate had us by the leash. Before I would let them land, I made them swear that they would eat only the provisions Circe had given us and never touch Helios's cattle.

Just as we beached our ship, a storm blew up. This cursed wind blew continuously by day and night for thirty days, trapping us on the island.

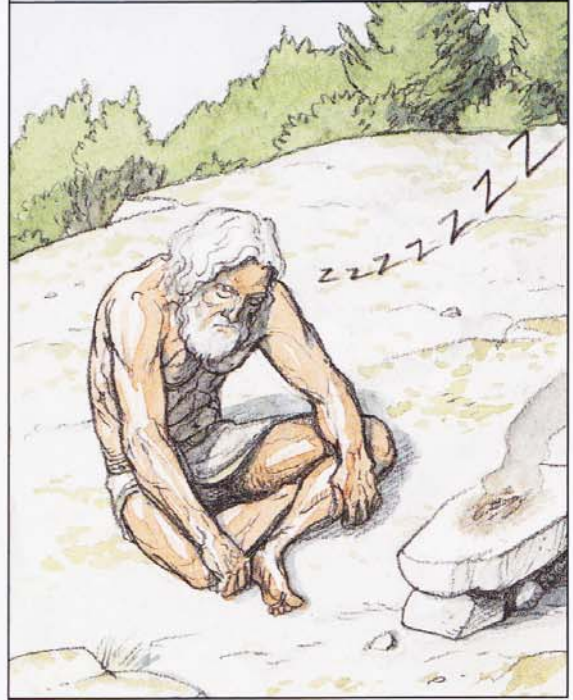


As long as Circe's food and wine held out, the men were content. But when at last it was gone, and starvation began to wrack their bodies, all eyes turned toward those magnificent cattle.

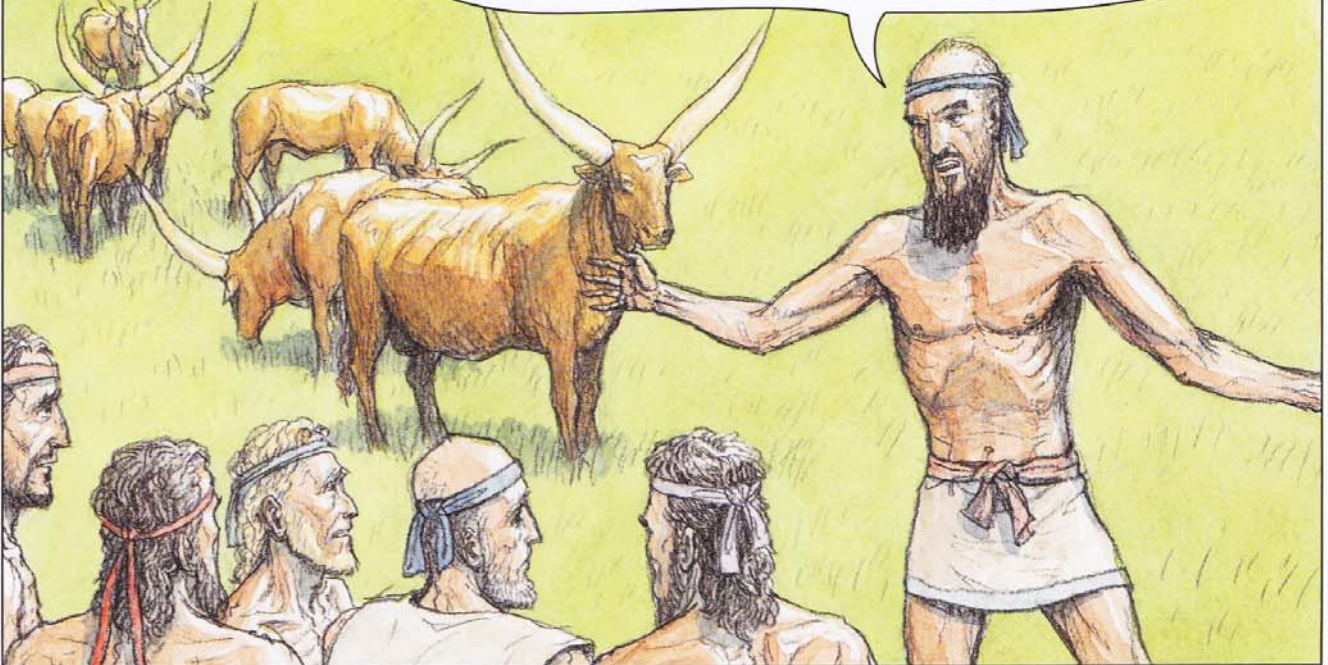
I reminded them of their oath, then went to climb the highest peak and ask the gods for help.

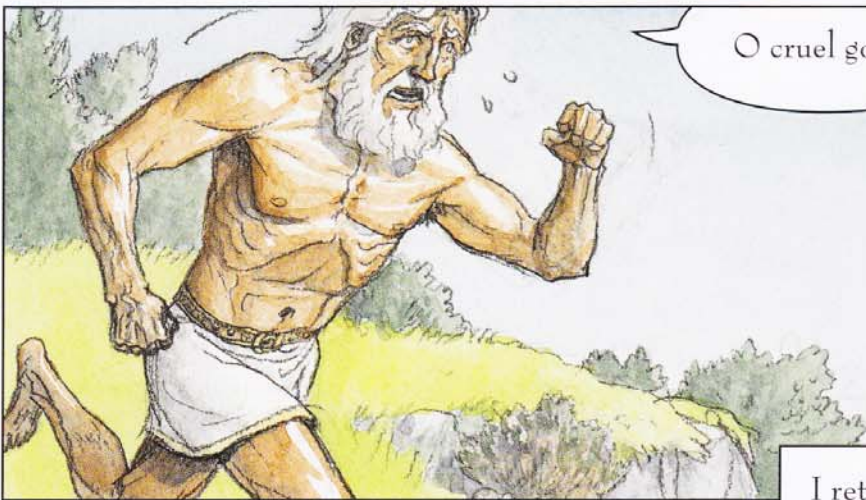
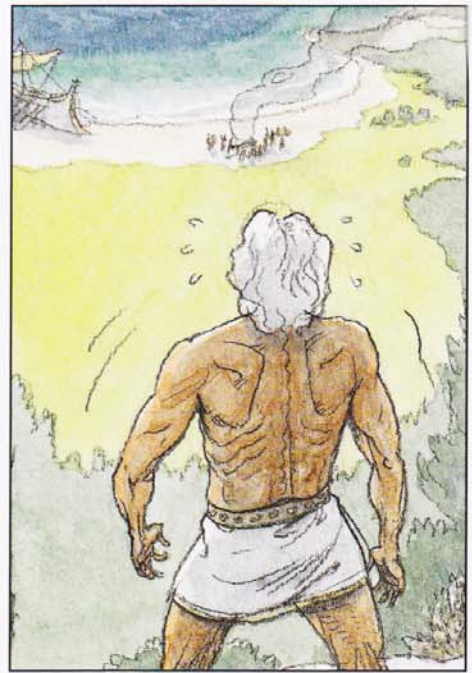
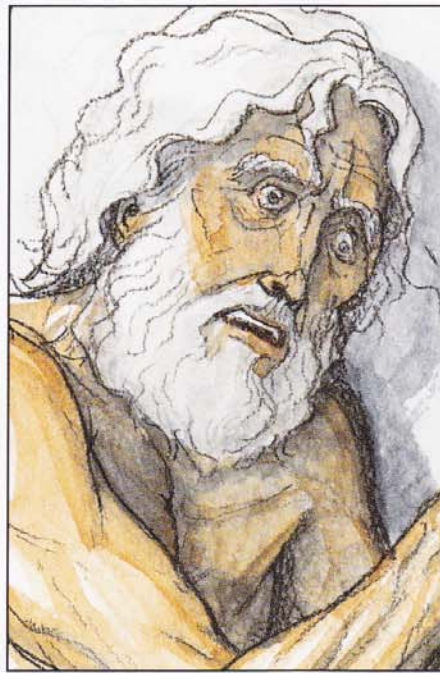


I prayed to all the gods of Olympus, but their answer was to close my eyes with an accursed sleep, while down on the shore Eurylochus hatched a fateful plan.



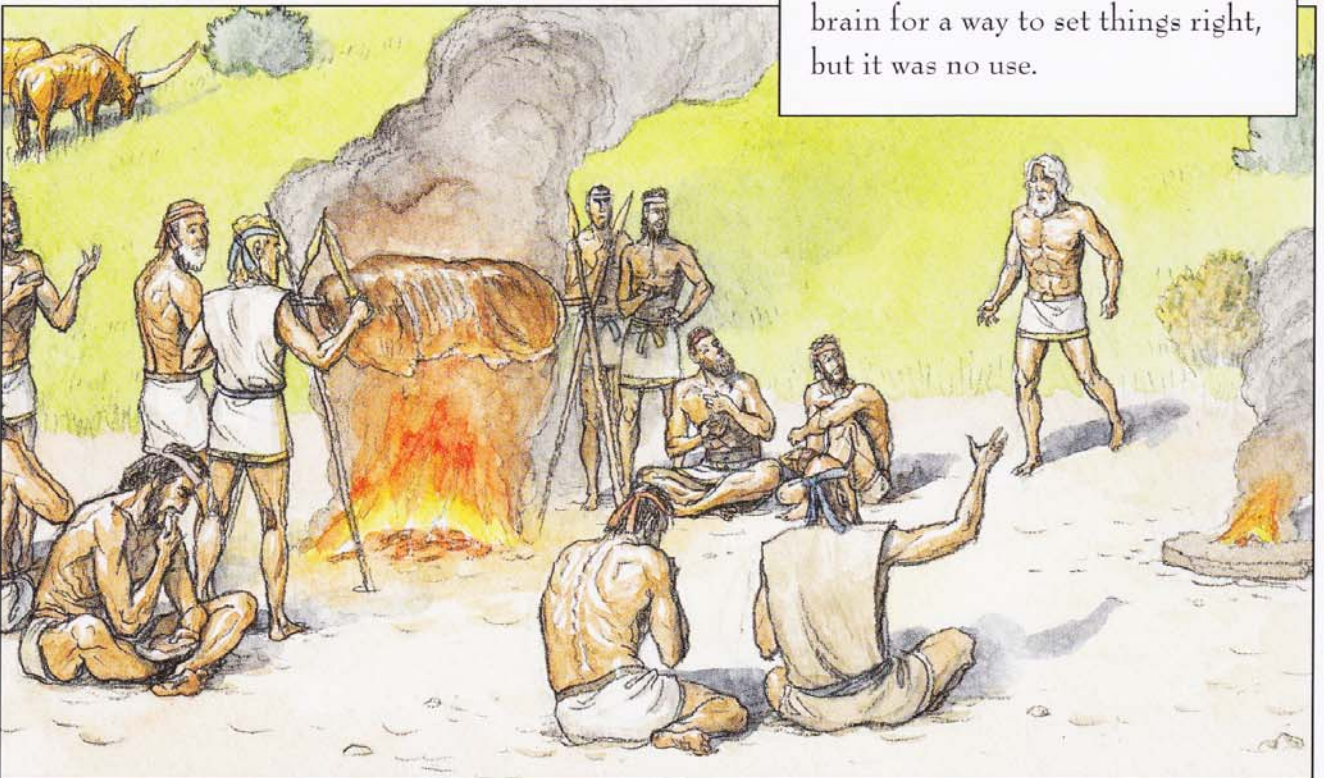
Comrades, hear me! All men fear death, but the worst death of all is starvation. It is repugnant, painful, and slow. We should not die pitifully on this beach, with these fat, majestic cattle so near at hand. We'll make sacrifices to the Sun God, promise him a grand temple on Ithaca, and ask his forgiveness. If he destroys us instead, at least we'll go down fighting!





O cruel gods!

I returned to the ship, racking my brain for a way to set things right, but it was no use.



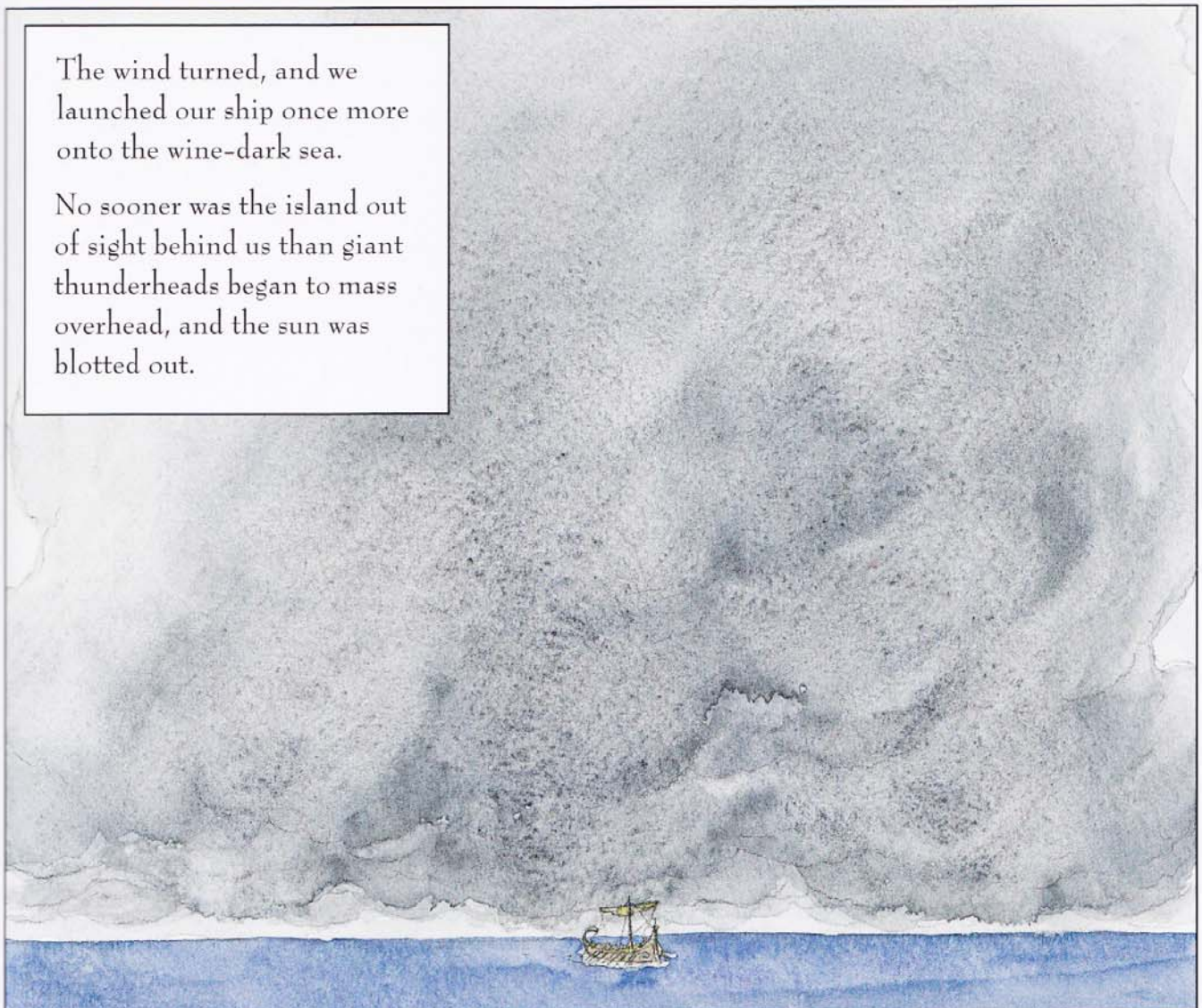
I knew we were doomed,
and soon fearful omens
confirmed it.

The hides began to crawl,
and the meat on the spits to
bellow like a herd of oxen.



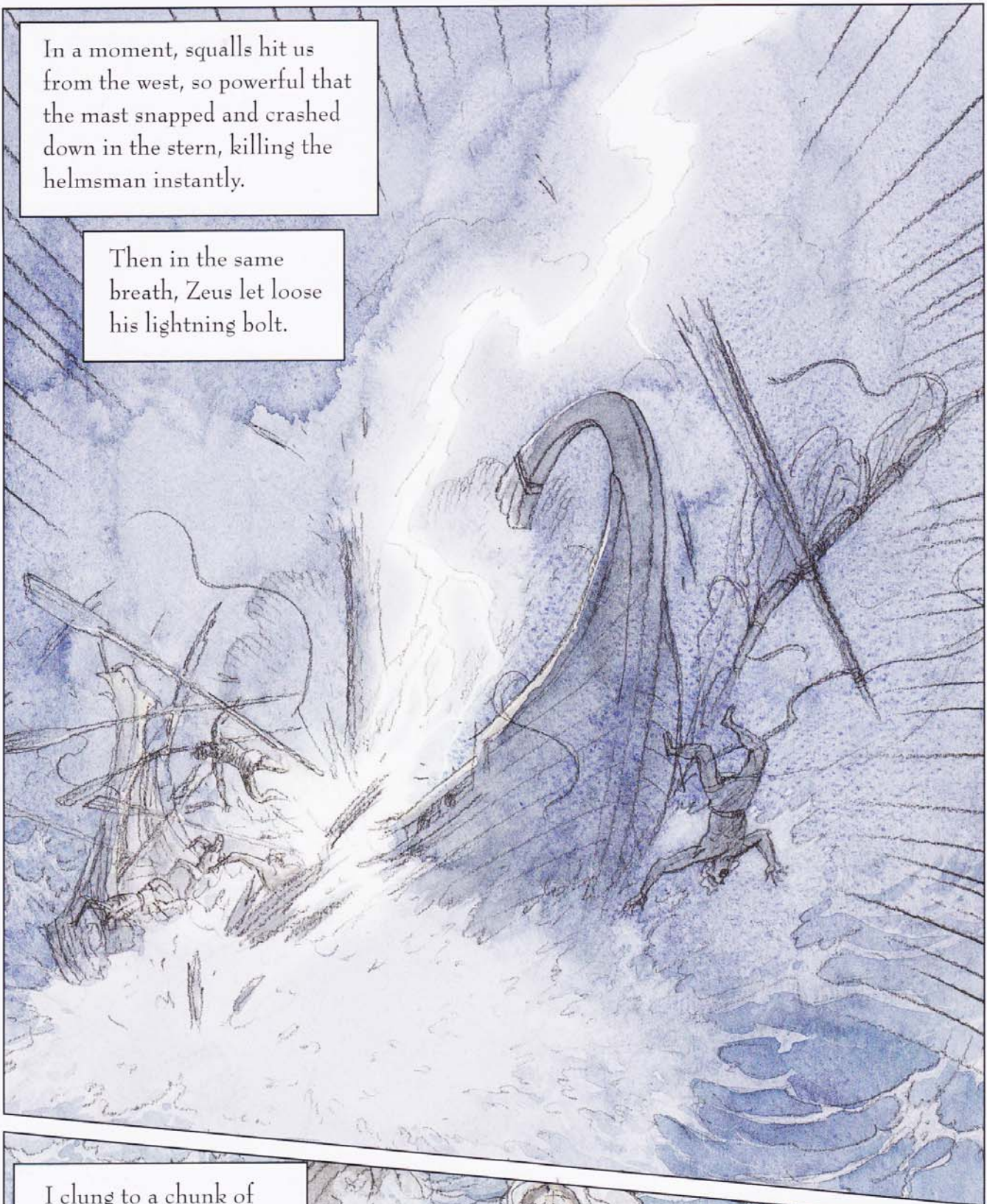
The wind turned, and we
launched our ship once more
onto the wine-dark sea.

No sooner was the island out
of sight behind us than giant
thunderheads began to mass
overhead, and the sun was
blotted out.



In a moment, squalls hit us from the west, so powerful that the mast snapped and crashed down in the stern, killing the helmsman instantly.

Then in the same breath, Zeus let loose his lightning bolt.

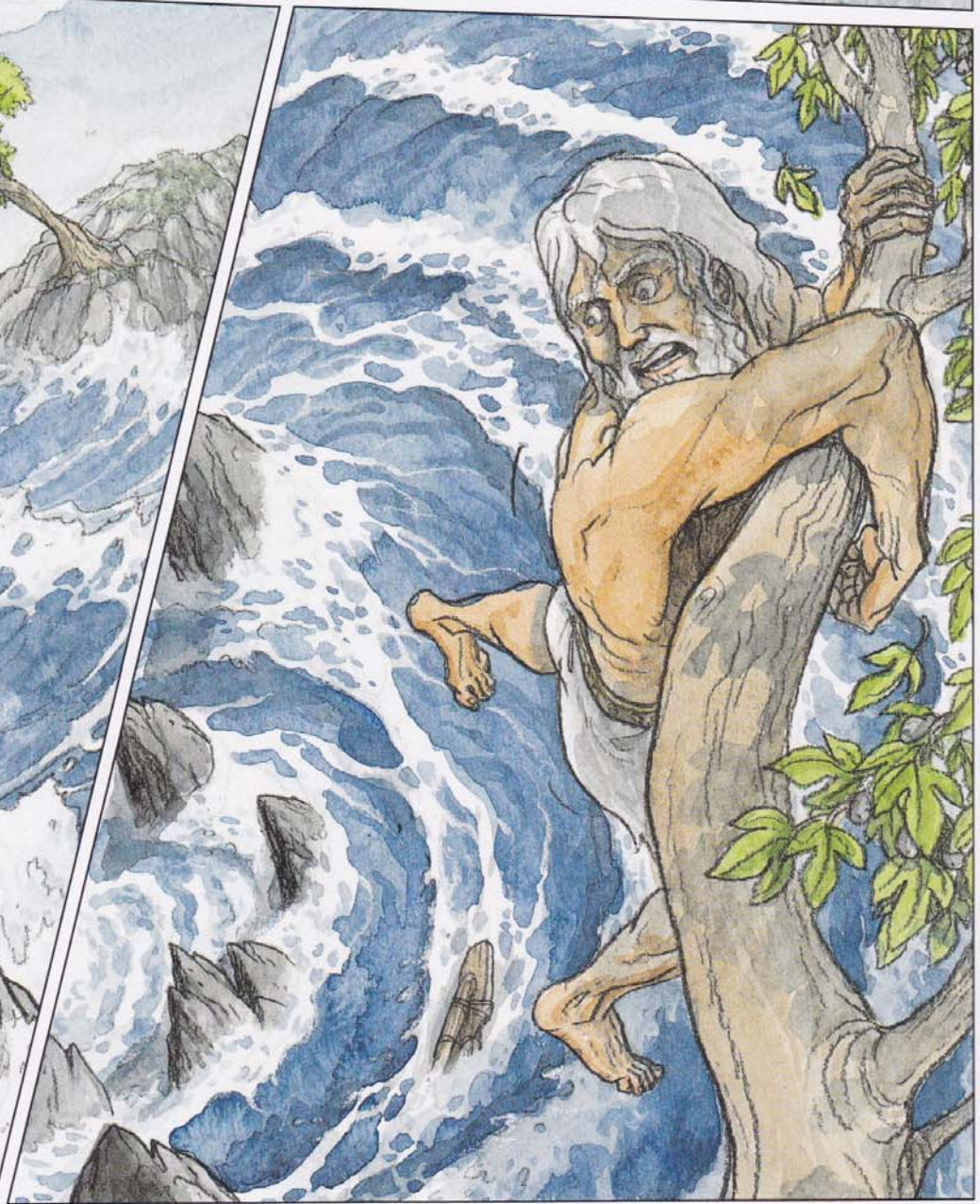
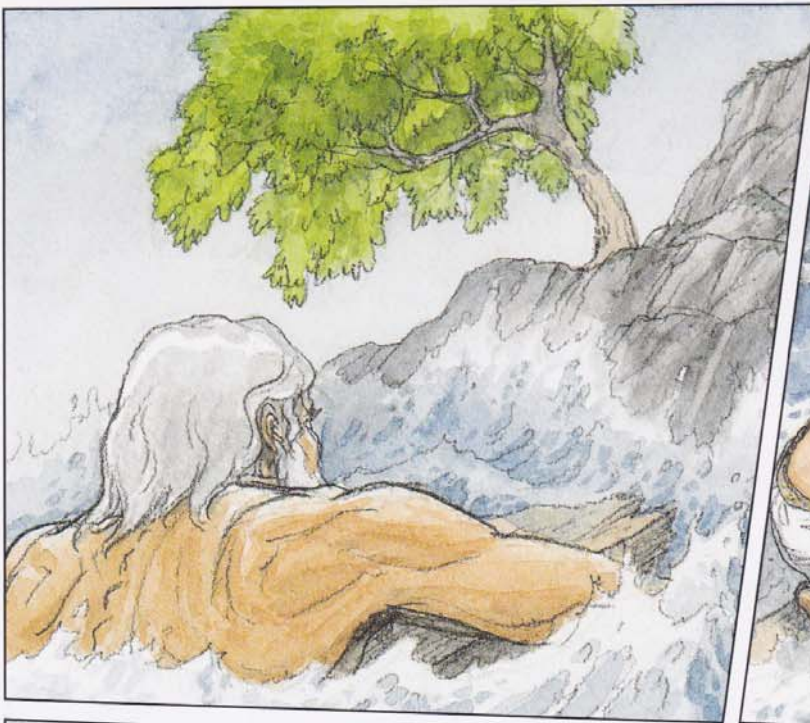


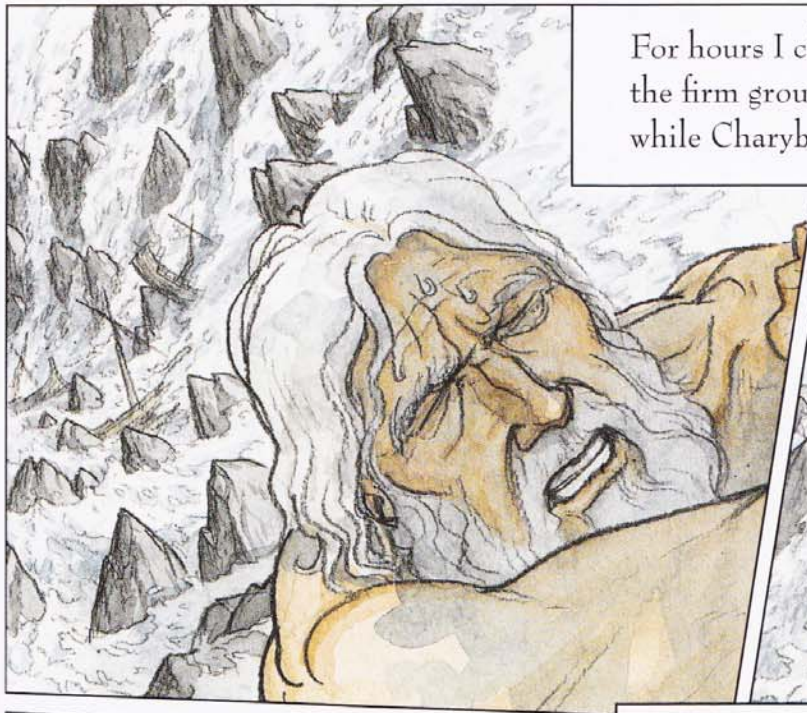
I clung to a chunk of the keel, and when part of the mast floated by, I was able to pull it in and bind it fast.



I rode this makeshift raft as the winds raged around me, and gradually they turned and drove me back on my course . . . back toward Scylla and Charybdis.





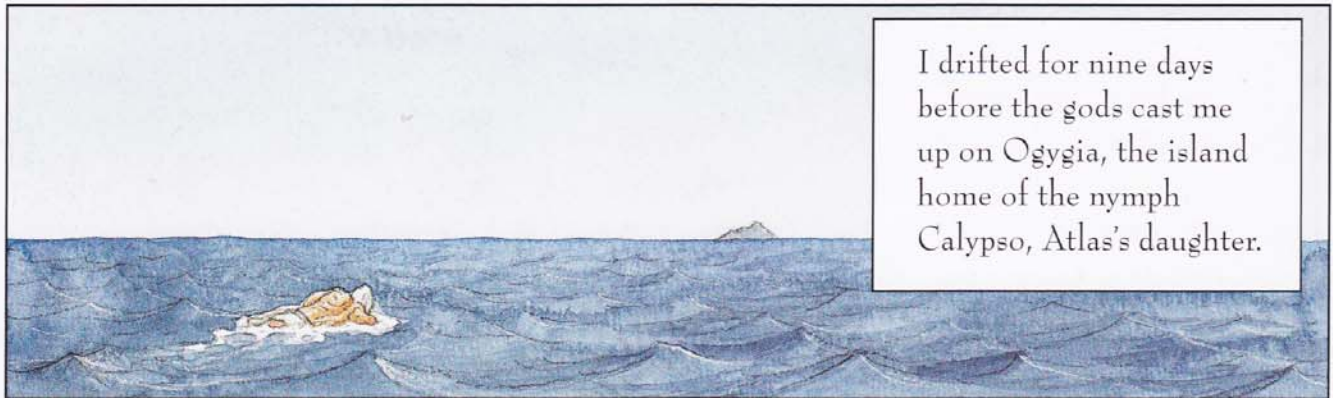
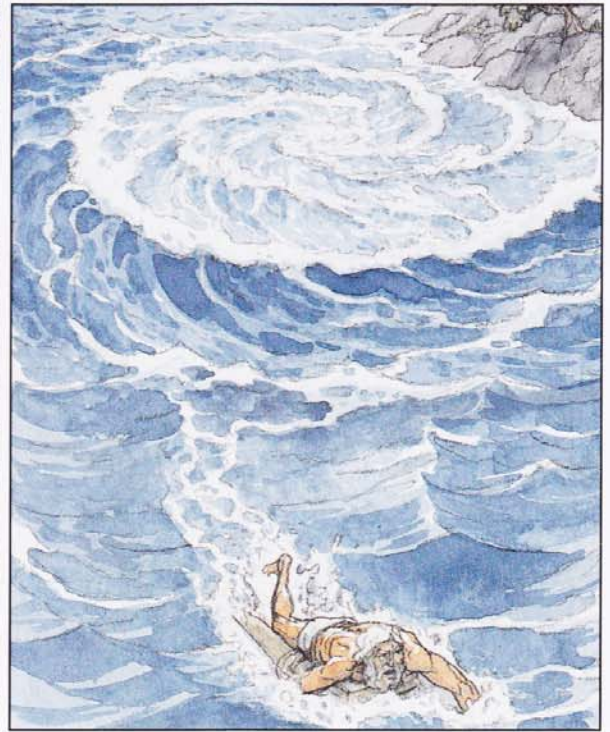


For hours I clung to that trunk, unable to reach the firm ground or even get a good foothold, while Charybdis gulped the ocean down.



And then . . .





I drifted for nine days
before the gods cast me
up on Ogygia, the island
home of the nymph
Calypso, Atlas's daughter.

There I was stranded
for seven long years.
Calypso wanted to keep
me there forever, make
me immortal — but I
wept every day for my
home, and at last she
set me free.

I sailed my raft on
the open sea for
seventeen days,
before Poseidon
wrecked me within
sight of your
shore.

Now your troubles are ended. My friend,
we've kept you here long enough. The ship is
ready. Come, princes, let's go and stow noble
Odysseus's goods beneath the benches, pile up
rugs so he may rest in the bow.

You'll be
home soon,
king of
Ithaca.

